

PANEL DISCUSSION REPORT

The Business Side of Psychology

Moderator: Ms. Ashya K. Salim

Panelists: Dr. Benzir Hussain, Mr. Sajad T. Ali, Mr. Brijesh J. Mathew, Ms. Mariyam Vidhu

Quick Brief Summary

The panel discussion 'The Business Side of Psychology' emphasized that mental health professionals must treat their expertise as a scalable business by identifying a specific niche and mastering knowledge capitalization. The speakers urged students and practitioners to move beyond traditional, under-valued service models by building strong professional brands on LinkedIn and adopting value-based pricing strategies.

Introduction

The session, titled 'The Business Side of Psychology,' was a professional panel discussion exploring the intersection of psychological practice and scalable business models. The panel featured Dr. Benzir Hussain (Consultant Psychiatrist), Mr. Sajad T. Ali (Healthcare Strategist), Mr. Brijesh J. Mathew (Leadership Consultant), and Ms. Mariyam Vidhu (Entrepreneur). Moderator Ms. Ashya K. Salim opened the session by introducing the panelists and emphasizing the importance of bridging the gap between clinical expertise and entrepreneurial success.

Main Theme: Bridging Clinical Expertise and Business Scalability

The central thesis of the discussion was that psychology professionals must evolve beyond traditional clinical roles to view their skills as a viable, scalable business. The speakers argued that by identifying a specific niche, leveraging digital platforms like LinkedIn, and understanding the mechanics of 'knowledge capitalization,' practitioners can move from being under-valued service providers to high-impact, financially successful entrepreneurs.

Key Areas Explored

Find Your Niche

Ms. Mariyam Vidhu and other panelists stressed the necessity of finding a specific niche within the vast field of psychology. By focusing on a particular problem — whether in schools, hospitals, or corporate settings — professionals can tailor their solutions to meet specific market demands. This involves talking directly to people in that niche, understanding their needs, and providing services accordingly.

Build Credibility Through LinkedIn

The speakers highlighted the importance of building professional credibility early in one's career. They advocated activating a LinkedIn profile during student days itself, where students and young professionals can document their learning and insights. Writing about one's studies and niche helps build credibility and a professional image early on, ensuring that by the time they enter the professional market, they have already established a reputation as knowledgeable authorities in their chosen field.

Learning by Doing

Panelists advised that, initially, professionals should prioritize gaining knowledge over salary. When working within an organization, it is valuable to directly understand all aspects of the business, such as client management, sales, and technology, rather than focusing narrowly on a single clinical role.

Knowledge Capitalization and Strategic Pricing

Mr. Brijesh J. Mathew provided a critical analysis of 'knowledge capitalization,' arguing that most psychology professionals in India are significantly under-valued. He challenged the audience to move away from arbitrary or low-ball pricing strategies driven by fear of losing opportunities, and instead encouraged practitioners to recognize the intrinsic value of their years of study and experience.

He emphasized that pricing should reflect the value provided to the client, not just a standard consultation fee. By comparing the disparity between international and local billing rates, he illustrated that the market is willing to pay for expertise when the professional has the confidence and conviction to demand it. He urged students to view their education as an investment that must yield significant returns through proper monetization.

Key Insights: Framework for Success

- Niche Specialization - Do not try to solve every problem; identify a specific area where your skills can provide the most value.
- Proactive Networking - Utilize LinkedIn to build a professional brand and demonstrate expertise before even entering the job market.
- Value-Based Pricing - Shift from being a 'commodity' to an 'expert' by pricing services based on the impact and solution provided, rather than market averages.
- Financial Literacy - Understand the importance of cash flow and business valuation to ensure the long-term sustainability of a practice.

Conclusion: A Call to Action

The session concluded with a powerful call to action for students and professionals to take ownership of their careers. The speakers encouraged the audience to stop relying on traditional, low-paying models and instead embrace an entrepreneurial mindset. The tone was one of empowerment, urging the next generation of psychologists to combine their 'feeling brain' with a strategic, business-oriented approach to create a sustainable and rewarding future.